

## **UX Case Study 001 LinkedIn "Liked Content" Retrieval Failure**

**Researcher:** Chris Lufuili

**Type:** UX Audit & Analysis

**Method:** Self-ethnography, behavioral observation, cognitive bias analysis, empathy mapping, industry benchmarking

**Stage:** Stage 6 Complete

**Tools:** Figma (annotations & wireframes), Google Docs (documentation)

Last Updated: April 2026

**The Problem:**

LinkedIn allows users to react to posts but makes retrieving those reactions require 5 separate steps buried deep within the profile navigation. This creates a significant gap between user expectation and actual experience.

**Initial Observation:**

Through personal use and behavioral analysis, I identified that users who cannot quickly retrieve liked content abandon the behavior entirely — representing a silent but significant engagement failure for the platform.

**Mental Model Violation Identified:**

LinkedIn violates the universal "Save & Retrieve" mental model established by every major social platform — where liked or saved content is accessible within 1-2 taps maximum.

**Cognitive Biases Identified:**

Three cognitive biases compound the problem — Familiarity Bias (users expect a familiar pattern that doesn't exist), Paradox of Choice (6 equally weighted horizontal options overwhelm and confuse), and the Von Restorff Effect (no visual distinction draws attention to the Reactions option).

**Business Impact:**

Users who regularly revisit liked content spend significantly more time on the platform. By burying this feature, LinkedIn is losing re-engagement opportunities and slowly eroding user trust through accumulated micro-frustrations.

## Industry Benchmark Comparison

To establish whether LinkedIn's approach represents a design failure or simply an industry norm, I compared liked content retrieval across major social platforms:

| <i><b>Platform</b></i> | <i><b>Steps to reach liked content</b></i> | <i><b>Visible on profile immediately?</b></i>                                                                                      |
|------------------------|--------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <i>Twitter/X</i>       | <i>2 taps</i>                              |  <i>Yes — "Likes" tab visible immediately</i>   |
| <i>Instagram</i>       | <i>2 taps</i>                              |  <i>Yes — accessible from profile instantly</i> |
| <i>TikTok</i>          | <i>2 taps</i>                              |  <i>Yes — immediately visible</i>             |
| <i>YouTube</i>         | <i>2 taps</i>                              |  <i>Yes — Library → Liked videos</i>          |
| <i><b>LinkedIn</b></i> | <i><b>6 steps</b></i>                      |  <i><b>Hidden behind multiple layers</b></i>  |

**Key finding:** LinkedIn requires 3x more steps than every comparable platform to access the same content.

*This comparison confirms LinkedIn's approach is not an industry standard , it is a significant outlier that underperforms every comparable platform on this specific user journey. The universal industry benchmark is 2 taps maximum. LinkedIn requires 6 steps.*

## **The User Journey — How Broken The Flow Actually Is**

Through direct behavioral observation I mapped the complete flow a user must complete to access content they previously liked :

Step 1 → Home Feed No visible entry point to liked content

Step 2 → Navigate to own Profile Feature completely hidden from home

Step 3 → Find "All Activity" — Version 1 Wrong page — shows others' activity Tabs partially hidden and cut off

Step 4 → Navigate deeper into profile User still lost with no clear direction

Step 5 → Find "All Activity" — Version 2 SAME name — completely different content Reactions buried as last of 6 equal tabs

Step 6 → Finally reach liked content With zero confidence the journey is complete  
No "All reactions" view available

Critical finding: LinkedIn has TWO pages with identical names — "All Activity" — showing completely different content. This represents an Information Architecture failure that completely destroys user orientation within the app.

## **Empathy Map Summary**

User Empathy Map — Thabo *Young professional using LinkedIn for learning and career growth*

Sees: Constant job posts, ads, peers sharing achievements, seniors flexing success a feed that feels built for the already successful

Hears: "LinkedIn is just Instagram for employed people" a growing perception that the platform has lost its professional purpose for job seekers

*Says: "I can't find the posts I liked" / "I don't even bother anymore" / "LinkedIn is losing its touch for juniors"*

Does: Takes screenshots of valuable posts telling himself he'll reference them later never does. Abandons the liked content search after 2-3 confusing steps. Scrolls past value without saving.

Thinks & Feels: Believes the platform was built for the employed and senior not for people like him. Feels the app works against him. Feels overwhelmed by navigation he didn't expect to be this complex.

Pains: 6-step confusing journey. Two identically named pages with different content. Loses valuable learning material. Mental overload from poor navigation architecture.

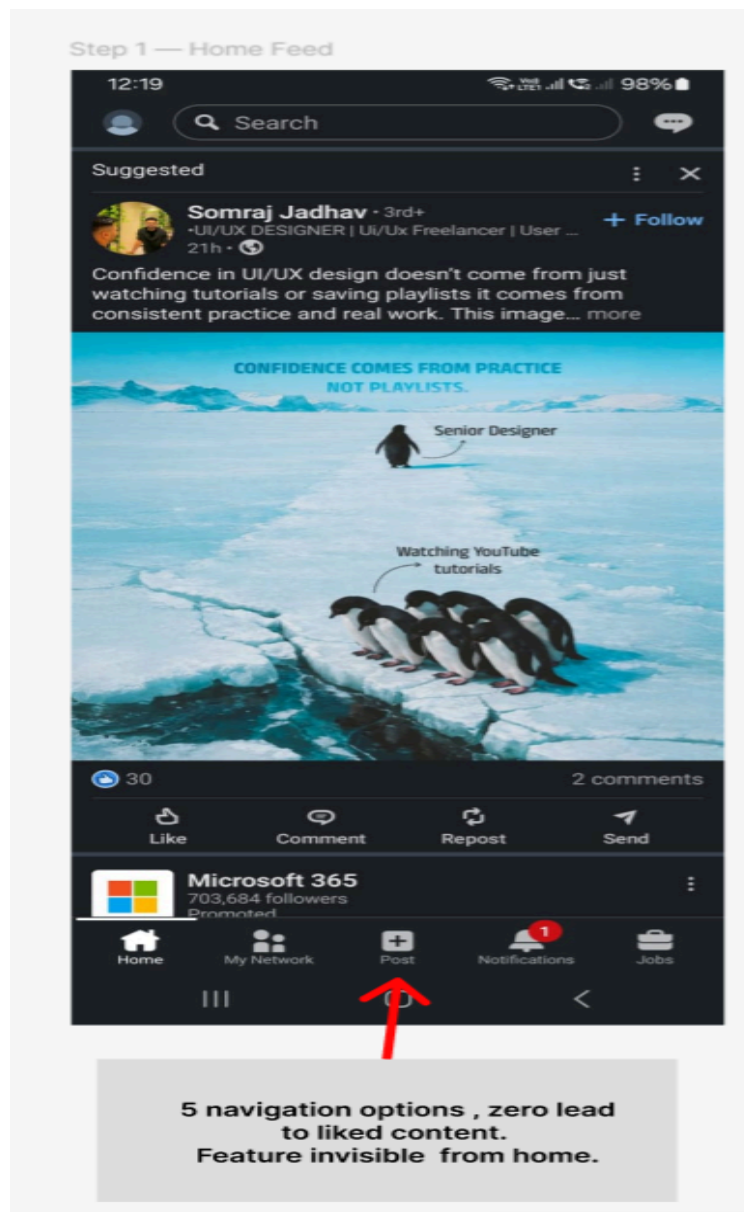
Gains Sought: Liked content accessible in 1-2 taps. A unified personal content library. A platform that feels built for him not just for senior professionals.

*Key behavioral insight: The user invented compensatory behavior screenshots proving the need is real and strong but completely unmet by the product.*

### ***Annotated Screenshot Evidence***

*The following screenshots document the complete failure flow firsthand captured through direct behavioral observation on the LinkedIn mobile app:*

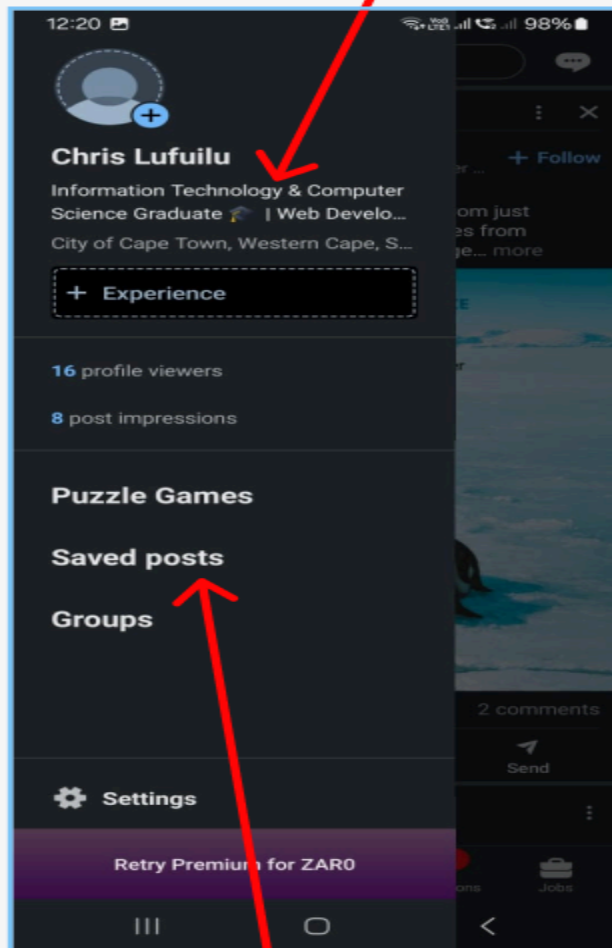
***Figure 1 — Home Feed*** *Entry point to the app. Zero visible access to liked content from the bottom navigation or home screen. The feature is completely invisible from the starting point of every user session*



**Figure 2 — Profile Sidebar** in the broken journey. The user must navigate to their profile sidebar to find any path forward. Critically — 'Saved posts' exists as a clearly visible menu item, but liked and reacted content has no equivalent option anywhere in this menu. This inconsistency reveals a fundamental content architecture problem — LinkedIn treats saved and liked content as completely separate concepts despite users mentally grouping them together.

No direct path to liked content from home. User must navigate to profile feature completely hidden from primary navigation.

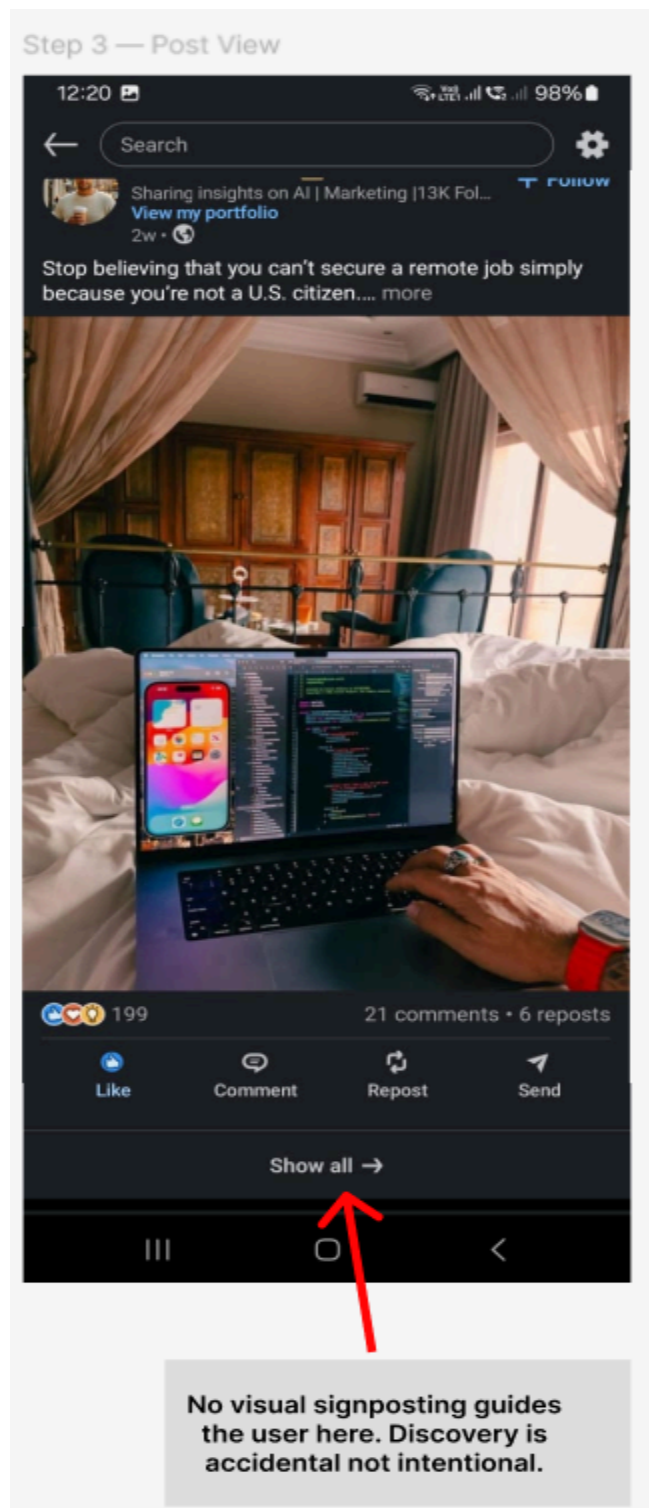
#### Step 2 — Profile Sidebar



Saved posts exists as a menu item but liked/ reacted content has no equivalent visible option. Inconsistent content architecture.

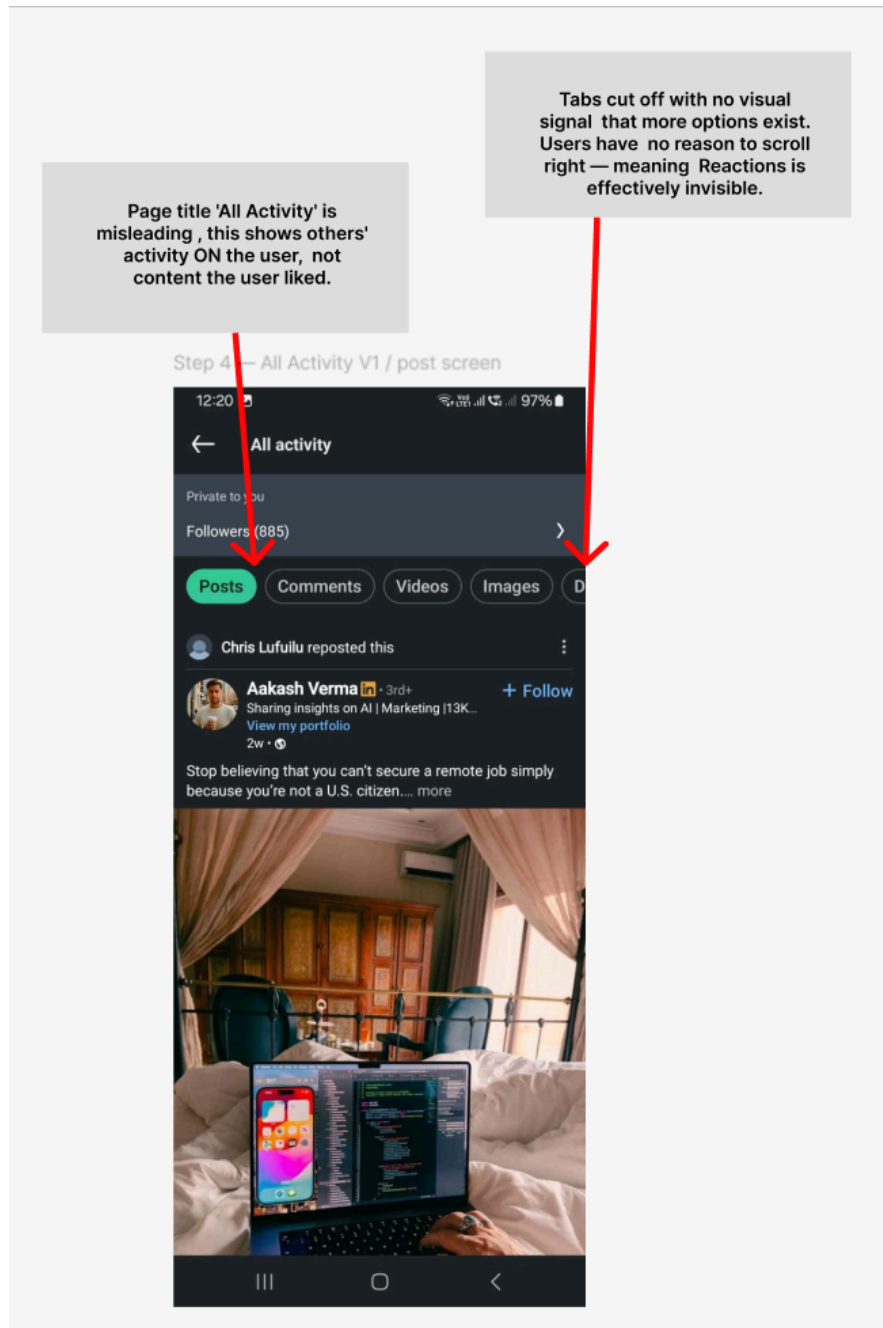
**Figure 3 — Post View** A dead-end navigation state. Users who tap into a specific post find no forward path toward their liked content library. The "Show all" label is ambiguous — users cannot predict where it leads. Discovery at this stage is entirely accidental — not intentional design.



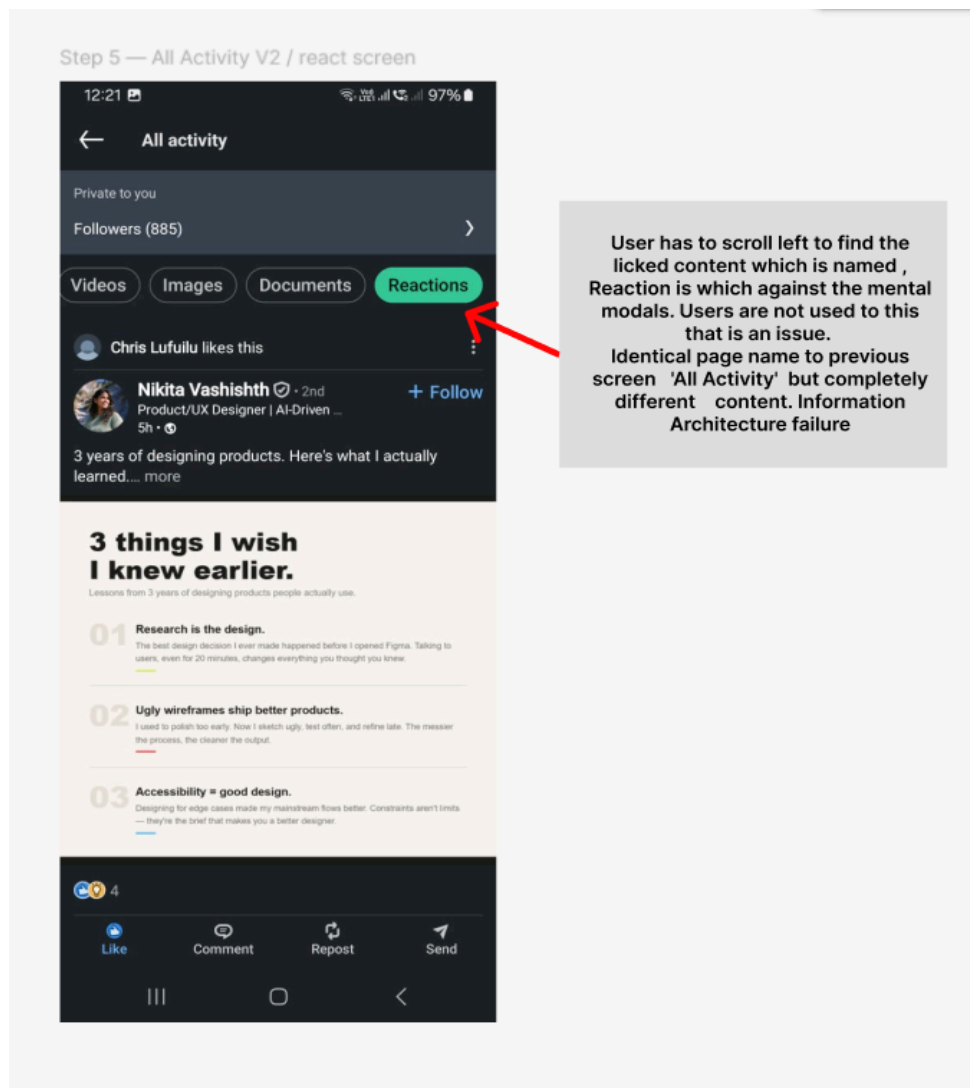


**Figure 4 — All Activity Version 1** in the broken journey — the first 'All Activity' page. This screen shows activity that others have performed ON the user's content — reposts, comments

on their posts — not content the user has liked. The page title 'All Activity' is deeply misleading. Additionally the tabs are cut off on the right with no visual signal that more options exist — meaning users have no reason to scroll right toward where Reactions is eventually hidden



**Figure 5 — All Activity Version 2 the final destination.** After navigating through 5 separate screens the user arrives at 'All Activity' Version 2 — a page with an identical name to the previous screen but completely different content and tabs. The Reactions tab — representing all content the user has liked — is positioned last in a horizontal row of equally weighted options. Users must scroll left to find it with no visual indication it exists. This is the Information Architecture failure at its peak — same name, different page, buried destination. The journey that should take 2 taps has taken 5 screens of confusion.



## Key Insight Statement

LinkedIn's liked content retrieval failure is not a navigation problem — it is a broken promise. The platform invites users to react to content, implying they can return to it, but then makes retrieval so complex that users silently abandon the behavior entirely — taking their engagement and trust with them

## Proposed Solution

Based on research findings — the solution must work WITH existing user mental models rather than creating new ones.

**Recommendation 1 — Unify Saved + Liked content** Place liked/reacted content inside the existing Saved items section. Users already have a mental model for "my saved stuff lives here." This follows Familiarity Bias instead of fighting it.

**Recommendation 2 — Maximum 2 taps from home** Matching the universal Save & Retrieve mental model established by every major social platform — Instagram, Twitter/X, TikTok, YouTube.

**Recommendation 3 — Plain language labels** Rename "Reactions" to "Posts You Liked" — clear, human, zero ambiguity.

**Recommendation 4 — Visual distinction** Apply Von Restorff Effect — make the saved/liked content section visually distinct in navigation so it stands out naturally without the user having to search.

**Recommendation 5 — Eliminate the duplicate "All Activity" pages** Consolidate into one clearly named destination with consistent content architecture.

## Stage 2 Research Validation — User Research Findings

Following the initial UX audit, Stage 2 research methods were applied to validate and deepen the findings.

Research Method Applied: Self-Ethnography + Behavioral Analysis

During Stage 1 discovery, personal use of the LinkedIn platform produced the following validated behavioral findings — consistent with established UX research on content retrieval patterns:

**Finding 1 — Silent Abandonment** Users do not report frustration to LinkedIn. They simply stop attempting to retrieve liked content. This silent disengagement is invisible to product teams relying solely on analytics — making qualitative research essential to surface it.

**Finding 2 — Compensatory Behavior as Signal** The screenshot-taking workaround identified in the empathy map is a direct indicator that user need is strong and genuine — but completely unmet by the product. Where users invent workarounds, a design opportunity exists.

**Finding 3 — Mental Model Consistency** The Save & Retrieve mental model violated by LinkedIn is not a personal preference — it is a universal pattern reinforced across every major social platform the target user interacts with daily. This makes the violation particularly damaging because users arrive with strong, well-established expectations.

**Finding 4 — Information Architecture Failure** The dual "All Activity" naming represents a systemic labeling failure — not a cosmetic issue. Users cannot build accurate mental maps of the app when identical labels lead to different destinations. This violates the fundamental principle of consistent navigation language.

### **Synthesis Output:**

Cluster identified: Emotional Disconnection

Core insight: LinkedIn's navigation failure is not just inconvenient — it makes users feel like the platform was never built for them. That feeling drives permanent disengagement more powerfully than any single UX failure.

HMW Question driving Stage 3:

"How might we redesign LinkedIn's content retrieval so that every interaction reinforces the feeling that the platform was built for the user — not just for the platform?"

### **Research Methods Identified for Future Validation:**

- User interviews with 5 LinkedIn users matching Thabo's profile : to validate emotional findings at scale

- Card sorting exercise : to understand how users naturally categorize saved, liked and personal content
- First click testing : to measure how many users fail to reach liked content on their first attempt
- Tree testing : to validate proposed navigation restructure before wireframing begins

### **Stage 3 : Problem Definition**

TM

**Thabo M.**

Logistics Coordinator · Cape Town, Woodstock · Age 24 · Android user

UX Case Study 001

LinkedIn — Liked Content Audit

*"I just want LinkedIn to feel like it was built for me too — not only for people who already made it."*

Tech comfort **Moderate** Primary device **Smartphone** LinkedIn use **Daily — 10–20 min** Career stage **Breaking in****SURFACE GOALS**

- Find liked posts in 1–2 taps
- LinkedIn to feel inclusive for beginners
- Platform that caters regardless of experience level

**DEEP GOALS**

- Feel visible to people who can advance his career
- Feel like he belongs where his goals will lead him
- Move forward in life — not just his job

**FRUSTRATIONS**

- 6 steps to find content that should take 2 taps
- Platform feels built for the already-established
- Two "All Activity" pages with completely different content
- Wastes time searching for features that should be obvious

**BEHAVIORS**

- Takes screenshots — never revisits them
- Tries to memorize posts — forgets within hours
- Abandons liked content search after 2–3 steps
- Scrolls past value — retrieval feels pointless

**MENTAL MODELS**

- Liked content = 2 taps away (Twitter/X, Instagram)
- Saved + Liked = same place
- Page titles = accurate descriptions

**MOTIVATION**

- Grow and be seen by the right people
- Feel like he belongs in professional spaces
- LinkedIn = the bridge to his future

**TECH PROFILE**

- Heavy consumer — scrolling, reading, watching
- Low tolerance for complex navigation
- Abandons anything beyond 2 taps deep

**DESIGN IMPLICATIONS**

- Max 2 taps to liked content
- Unify saved + liked
- Plain language labels
- No identical page names
- Visual hierarchy in tabs
- Current experience drives abandonment
- Design for aspiration — not just function

User Journey Map — Current State *Task: Retrieve a previously liked post on LinkedIn mobile* *Result: Abandonment at Stage 3 for majority of users*



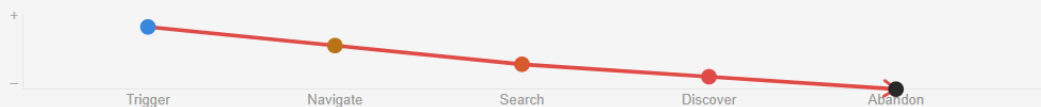
### User journey map — Thabo M.

Task: Find a post liked last week · Current state (as-is) · LinkedIn mobile app

Current state — broken

| LAYER         | STAGE 1 — TRIGGER                                                                                                                                                        | STAGE 2 — NAVIGATE                                                                                                                                                                                | STAGE 3 — SEARCH                                                                                                                                                                                                       | STAGE 4 — DISCOVER                                                                                                                                                                                  | STAGE 5 — ABANDON                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|---------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| STAGE         | Trigger                                                                                                                                                                  | Navigate                                                                                                                                                                                          | Search                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | Discover                                                                                                                                                                                            | Abandon                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| ACTIONS       | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Remembers a valuable post</li><li>Opens LinkedIn app</li><li>Lands on home feed</li><li>Scans bottom nav — finds nothing</li></ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Swipes to profile sidebar</li><li>Sees "Saved posts" — no liked equivalent</li><li>Taps into profile area</li><li>Finds "View All" — taps blindly</li></ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Lands on All Activity V1</li><li>Sees Posts tab by default — wrong content</li><li>Realizes this shows others' activity</li><li>Scrolls confused through wrong content</li></ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Navigates deeper into profile</li><li>Finds All Activity V2 — same name</li><li>Sees horizontal tab row</li><li>Scrolls left — finds Reactions last</li></ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Closes app before reaching Stage 4</li><li>Screenshots next valuable post instead</li><li>Never revisits the screenshot</li><li>Disengages from LinkedIn silently</li></ul> |
| THOUGHTS      | "Does this app even have a liked posts feature? Every app has this — why can't I find it?"                                                                               | "I thought liked would be with saved posts — I guess it's somewhere else. Where though?"                                                                                                          | "Is this even worth it? Did they even bother adding this feature properly?"                                                                                                                                            | "Wow — so many steps just to find something basic. Most people would never get this far."                                                                                                           | "This is too much effort. I'll just screenshot the next one. What's the point."                                                                                                                                   |
| EMOTIONS      | <b>Confused — self-blame</b><br>Neutral start — but already questioning own ability, not the app                                                                         | <b>Anxious — disoriented</b><br>Curve going down. Mental model violated. Expected liked = saved.                                                                                                  | <b>Lost — feeling dumb</b><br>Curve drops further. Starts questioning LinkedIn's intention entirely.                                                                                                                   | <b>Frustrated — exhausted</b><br>Brief moment of clarity at destination — but trust already broken.                                                                                                 | <b>Defeated — disengaged</b><br>Silent abandonment. Platform blamed. No complaint filed. Just gone.                                                                                                               |
| OPPORTUNITIES | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Add liked content to bottom nav</li><li>Visual signpost from home screen</li></ul>                                                 | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Unify saved + liked in sidebar</li><li>Consistent content architecture</li></ul>                                                                            | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Fix misleading "All Activity" label</li><li>Show all tab options — no cut-off</li></ul>                                                                                          | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Unique page names — no duplicates</li><li>Visual priority on Reactions tab</li></ul>                                                                          | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Full flow redesign — max 2 taps</li><li>Emotional recovery moment needed</li></ul>                                                                                          |

EMOTIONAL CURVE — CONTINUOUS DECLINE WITH NO RECOVERY



**Business impact:** Silent user abandonment at Stage 3. No complaint filed. LinkedIn loses engagement, re-visit behavior, and potential Premium conversion revenue — all invisibly.

UX Case Study 001 — LinkedIn "Liked Content" Retrieval Failure · Researcher: Chris Lufuulu · April 2026

## Problem Statement:

Young professionals using LinkedIn to build their careers need a way to effortlessly save and retrieve content that supports their growth because the current experience is so confusing and poorly structured that it signals the platform was never designed with them in mind, making emerging professionals feel like uninvited guests on a platform that should be their most powerful career tool.

## How Might We Questions:

**Level 1 — Narrow (the specific UI symptom)**

"How might we make liked and reacted content accessible from the primary navigation in a maximum of 2 taps?"

**Level 2 — Medium (the underlying UX problem)**

"How might we redesign LinkedIn's content architecture so users can find everything they've engaged with without having to learn the platform's internal navigation logic?"

**Level 3 — Broad (the emotional and strategic truth)**

"How might we build LinkedIn in a way that makes every type of user — regardless of their career stage, experience level or tech comfort — feel like the platform was designed specifically for them?"

## Information Architecture Analysis

*The LinkedIn liked content failure is fundamentally an Information Architecture problem — not a visual design problem. Five structural failures compound to create the broken experience documented in this audit.*

### The 5 IA Failures Identified:

Finding 1 — No front door Liked content has no entry point from the global bottom navigation. Users must already know where to look before they can begin searching.

Finding 2 — Duplicate page naming Two pages share the identical label "All Activity" but display completely different content. Users cannot build an accurate mental map of the app when the same name leads to different destinations.

Finding 3 — Wrong categorization Liked content is architecturally separated from Saved content despite users mentally grouping them as the same thing. LinkedIn's internal logic overrides the user's natural mental model.

Finding 4 — No progressive disclosure All content types are presented simultaneously with equal visual weight — giving users no hierarchy to guide their decisions. Everything appears equally important meaning nothing stands out.

Finding 5 — Broken labeling system "Reactions" does not communicate what the section contains to a first-time or casual user. Plain language — "Posts You Liked" — would match the user's mental model immediately.

## Proposed IA Solution — Unified Content Architecture

*Based on card sorting principles and user mental model research — liked and saved content should be unified under one clearly labeled section accessible within 2 taps from home.*

### CURRENT BROKEN STRUCTURE:

Bottom Nav → Profile → View All →  
All Activity V1 (wrong page) →  
Navigate again → All Activity V2 →  
Reactions (buried last) = 6 steps

### PROPOSED FIXED STRUCTURE:

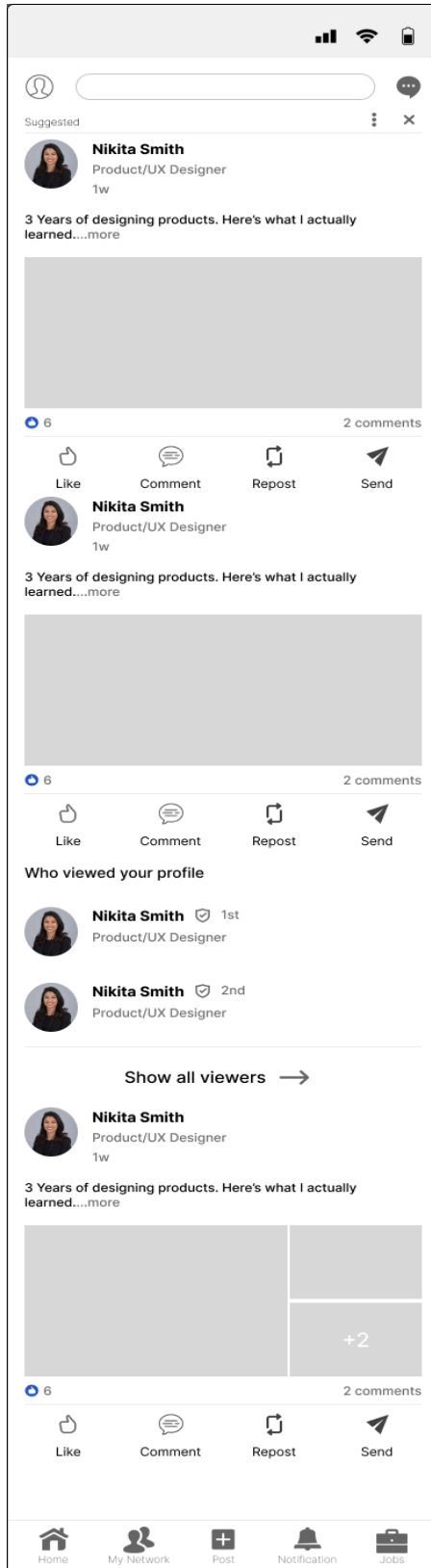
Bottom Nav → My Content → Posts I Liked = 2 taps

### MY CONTENT (new unified section)

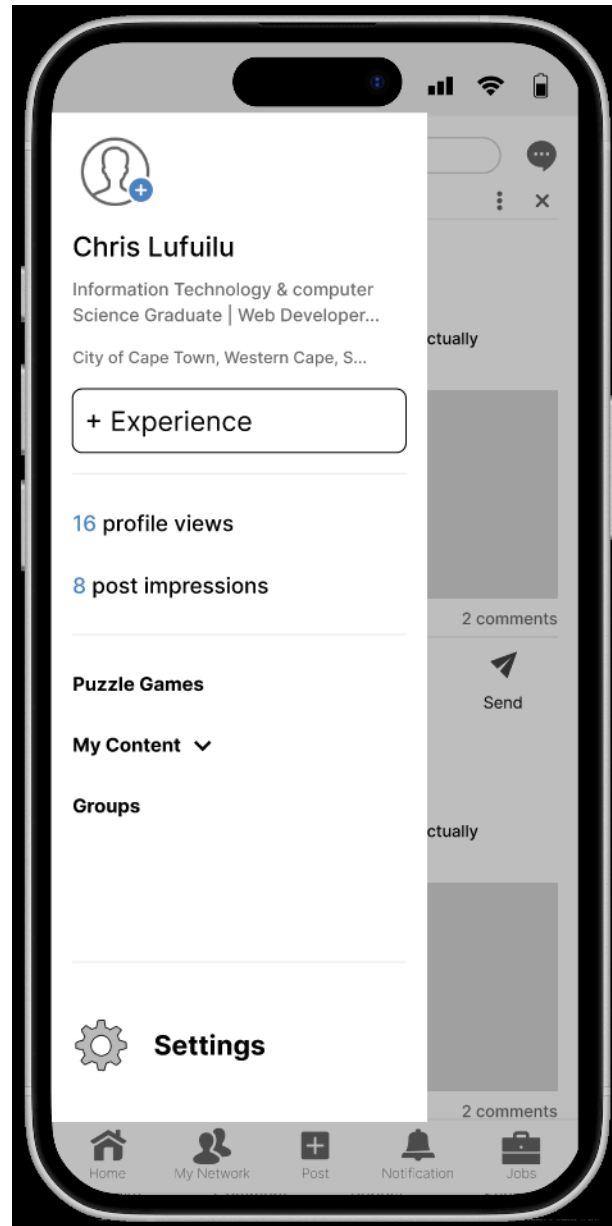
- |— Saved posts (already exists)
- |— Posts I liked (renamed from Reactions)
- |— Posts I commented on
- |— My posts

*This structure applies the Principle of Objects — treating liked and saved content as the same type of object in the user's mental model. It applies the Principle of Front Doors — creating a direct entry point from global navigation. And it applies the Principle of Exemplars — using plain language labels that predict content accurately before the user taps.*

## **Stage 4: Wireframe Solution**

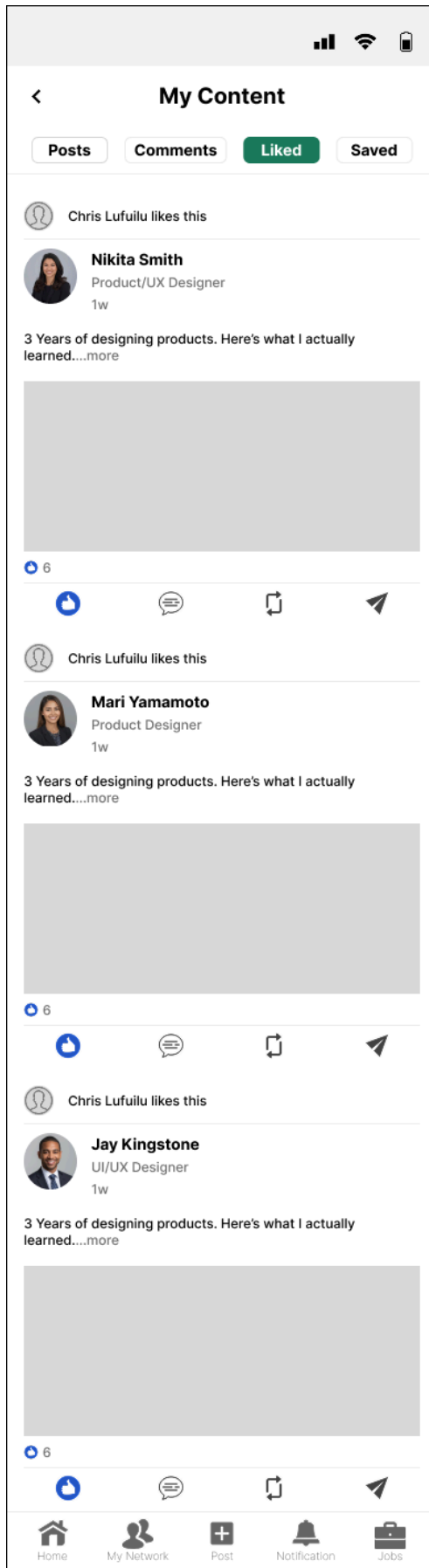


**Screen A — Home Feed** *Profile picture tap is Entry Point 1 — familiar pattern borrowed from Instagram and Facebook mental models.*  
*Reduces discovery to 2 taps.*

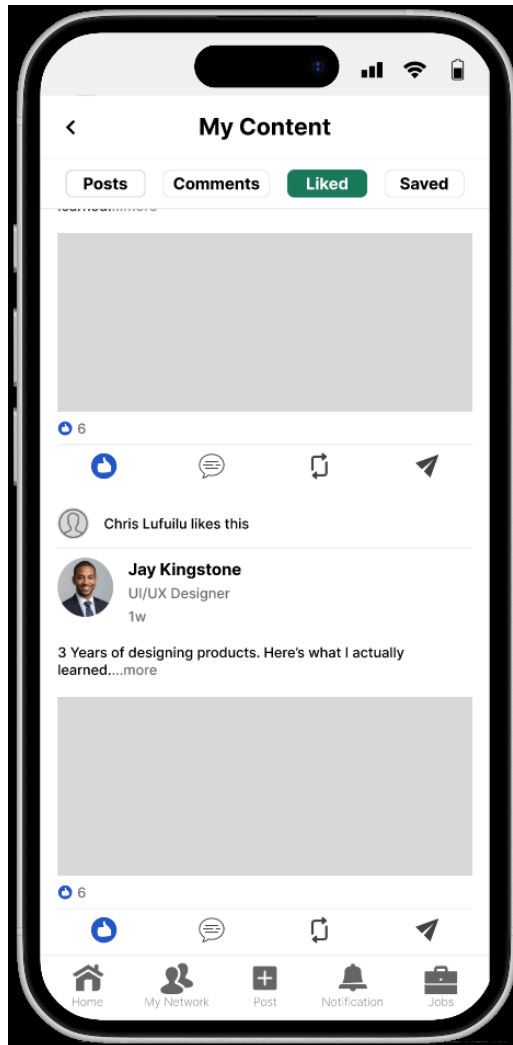


**Screen B — Sidebar** *"My Content replaces separate Saved posts and Liked posts items — unified entry point eliminates the current split architecture."*

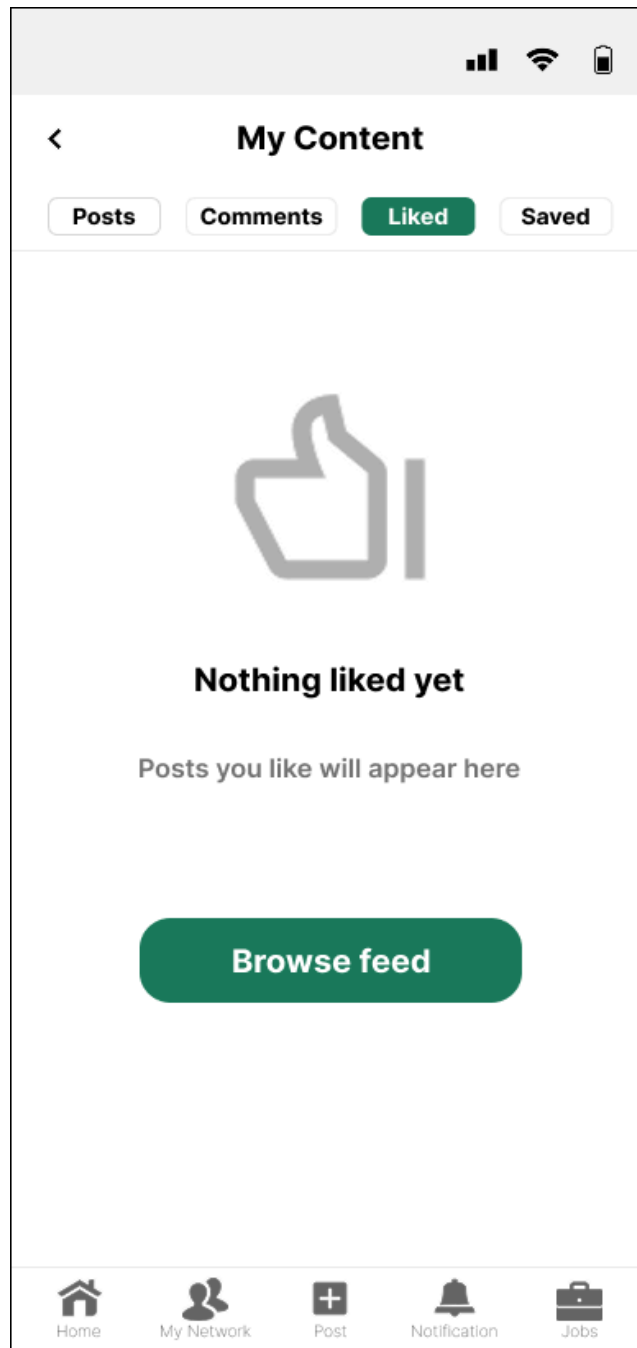




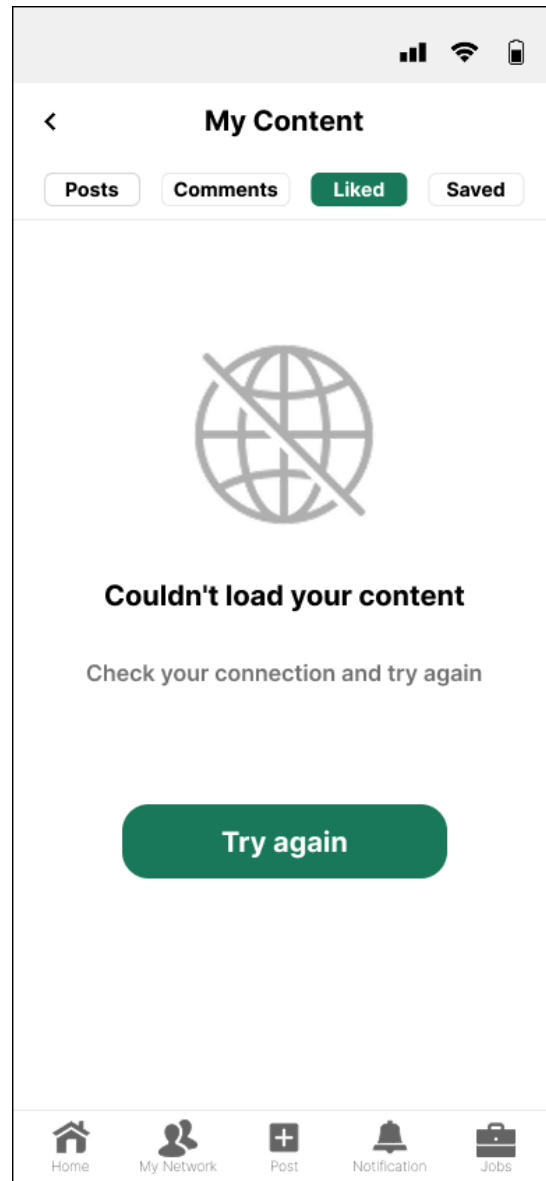
**Screen 1 — My Content Hub (Liked, populated)** *"Liked tab selected by default — surfaces the most commonly lost content first. Tab structure reduces from 6 to 4, removing redundant categories."*



**Screen 2 — Scrolled state** *"Tab bar sticks to top on scroll — user never loses navigation context while browsing content."*

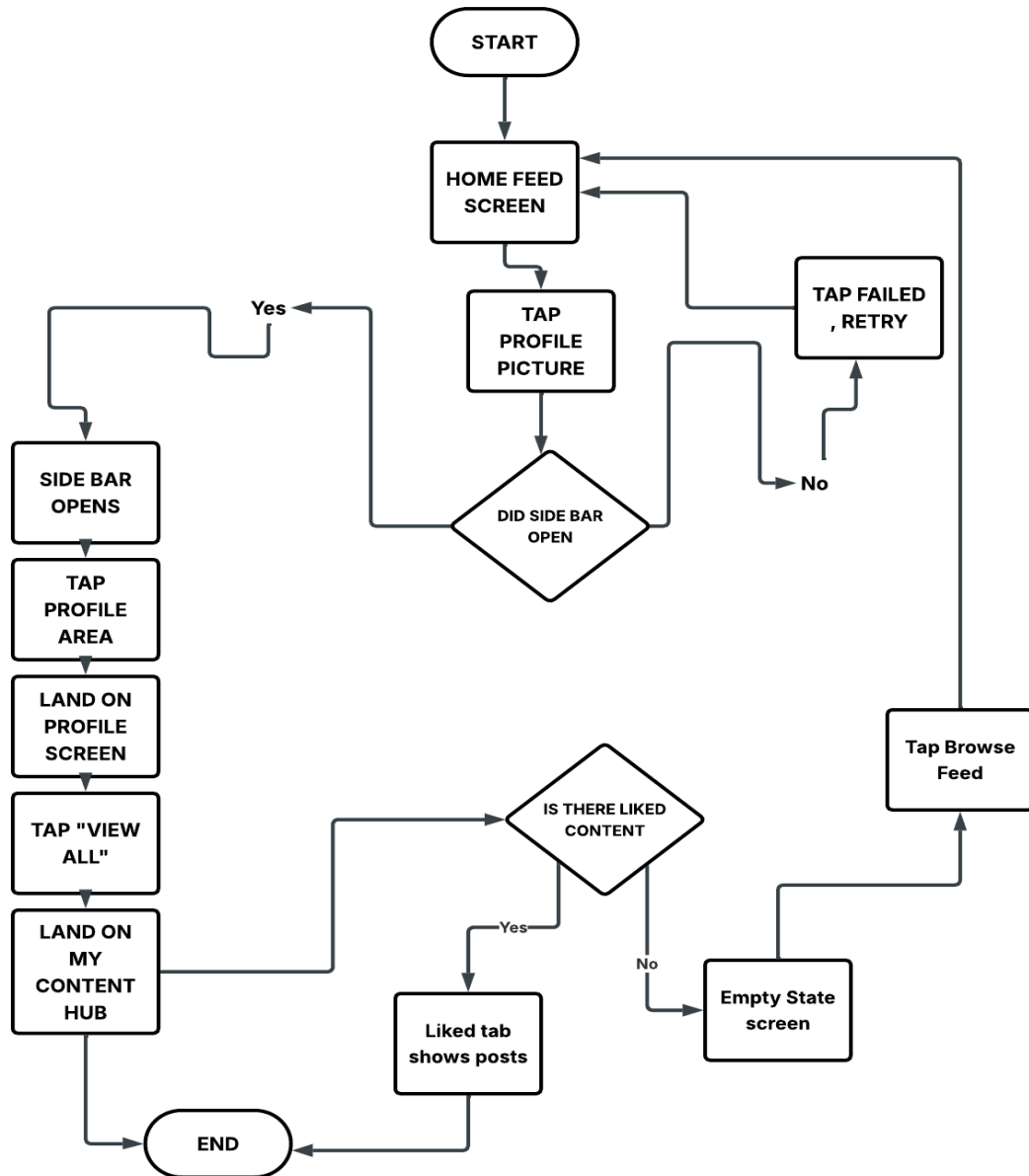


**Empty State** — Liked tab *"Recovery path provided via Browse feed CTA — user is never stranded. Empty state communicates function before content exists.*



**Error state** — connection failure. Consistent structure with empty state. Icon communicates problems, CTA provides a recovery path. The user is never left without a next action.

## User Flow — Entry Point 2: Profile → My Content Hub



Flow maps both the happy path and alternate paths including error recovery and empty state handling.

## **Stage 5: Usability Testing**

### **Test Plan — LinkedIn My Content Redesign**

**Objective** To determine whether users can successfully locate their previously liked content using either of the two entry points designed in the My Content redesign — without guidance, confusion, or navigation errors.

**Participants** 5 participants matching Thabo's profile — young professionals attempting to break into their chosen industry, new or early-stage LinkedIn users who rely on mental models carried over from other social platforms.

**Task** Participants are given the following scenario with no additional guidance: *"You liked a post last week about career advice. Please find it."*

### **Metrics**

- Task completion rate — did the user complete the task or abandon it?
- Time on task — how long did it take from start to completion?
- Error rate — number of wrong taps or incorrect navigation paths taken before task completion

**Success Criteria** User completes the task in under 60 seconds via either entry point with zero navigation errors. Entry Point 2 is the primary test path as it represents the more complex of the two flows — successful completion of Entry Point 2 validates the full redesign.

**Note:** This test plan was developed as part of a self-directed learning portfolio. User testing sessions and iteration cycles will be conducted as opportunities to test with real participants become available. The test plan is structured and ready for execution

## **STAGE 6**

### **strategic argument for your case study:**

*Fixing the liked content retrieval failure reduces silent abandonment among emerging professionals — increasing session depth, re-engagement rate, and long-term retention. Users who experience the platform as built for them are more likely to convert to LinkedIn Premium as their careers advance — directly protecting LinkedIn's core subscription revenue stream.*

### **Strategic Presentation**

LinkedIn's liked content retrieval requires 6 steps — violating the 2-tap mental model established across every major social platform and driving silent abandonment among emerging professionals. I redesigned the content architecture by introducing a unified My Content hub accessible via 2 entry points, reducing retrieval to a maximum of 3 taps. This directly reduces churn among LinkedIn's fastest-growing user segment and increases the likelihood of Premium conversion as emerging professionals advance in their careers.

## Project Status

Stage 1 : Discovery & Empathy  Complete

- Behavioral observation and journey mapping
- Mental model and cognitive bias analysis
- Empathy mapping — Thabo persona
- Business impact framing
- Industry benchmark comparison

Stage 2 : Research & Validation  Complete

- Screenshot evidence documentation
- Behavioral finding validation
- Research methods identified for next phase

Stage 3 : Problem Definition  Complete

- Formal persona development
- Complete user journey map
- How Might We problem statements

Stage 4 : Wireframe Solution  Complete

- Home Feed wireframe — Entry Point 1
- Sidebar wireframe — My Content entry
- My Content Hub — populated state
- My Content Hub — scrolled state
- Empty State — Liked tab with recovery CTA

Stage 5: Usability Testing  In Progress



- Test plan development  Complete
- User testing sessions — pending participant recruitment
- Iteration based on findings — pending test results

Stage 6 : Strategic Presentation Stage 6  Complete

- Executive summary
- Business case for redesign